were also suggestions from some Chinese officials that this deal was not entirely sincere. [103] Discussions nonetheless took place between Indian and Chinese officials in 1960 to review the historical record and showed a great disparity between their interpretations. In fact, in 1960, China advanced a new claim line in Aksai China farther to the west than what it had previously indicated in 1956. [104] The two sides therefore made no headway. As late as July and August 1962, negotiations and notes were being exchanged between Indian and Chinese officials. A last ditch offer by India to negotiate in July 1962 was rebuffed by China and was criticized by political leaders and the media in India. [105]

Although India had been preparing for conflict from 1959 onwards, several decisions were made which proved fatal in hindsight. Preparations were made only for a limited conflict with China and insufficient attention was paid to logistics. In fact, India's military budget decreased after 1960, as the country continued to prioritize development over defence. Even on the security front, not enough equipment was imported, although an agreement was signed for Soviet MiG-21 in the belief that it would help deter China. Indeed, Indian military leaders, including the former Army Chief Gen. K.S. Thimayya, who distrusted China from his experiences in Korea, understood that India was entirely unprepared for a major conflict. [106]

At the same time, the Intelligence Bureau assessed that China was only advancing in unoccupied territory, and therefore recommended more Indian posts. Nehru also had faith in international opprobrium deterring a major conflict with China. All of this contributed after 1959 to India's 'forward policy' of establishing posts and patrolling at advanced positions, in response to China's own forward positions. The forward policy seemed, at first, to work, deterring a Chinese patrol in Ladakh. But these posts were more observational than operational and were between old and new Chinese claim lines. China after all had been steadily building up its own forward presence for some time. [107]

But while negotiations and posturing had continued for years, the decision by Beijing to go to war was made quickly and decisively. In mid-